

» FIFA WORLD CUP SPOTLIGHT



Beyond football: Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha's World Cup heroics earned him global recognition, including the rare honour of having a newly discovered sea slug species, *Aldisa vozinha*, named after him. GETTY IMAGES

This FIFA World Cup proved that there is room for every dream

From Cape Verde's fearless debut and Egypt's breakthrough to Paraguay's grit and Norway's dream run, the expanded FIFA World Cup has shown that the tournament's finest stories are **not always written** by its biggest teams.

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Everyone gears up for the FIFA World Cup with a favourite team in mind. More often than not, the team you pick is a major contender for the title, features your favourite player or boasts a storied

legacy that you grew up admiring. But during the course of the tournament, there are less-heralded sides that make you sit up and take notice.

The 'underdogs', as we call them, form an essential part of sports

fandom. **They may not have the history or the flair to rival the favourites, but their unbridled team spirit and, sometimes, even a touch of charisma draw neutrals to them.**

The 2026 World Cup was no different. An expanded 48-team